

Talking Points

Utopia Lost

By **Madhu Jain**

The once-bohemian Cholamandal Artists' Village is now a staid 50 years old

It was evening by the time the two artists reached Injambakkam, on the outskirts of Madras. Chennai was still Madras in 1966, and the Cholamandal Artists' Village was little more than a gleam in the eye of its makers. Exhausted, Velu Viswanadhan and RB Bhaskaran slept under the open sky, guarding the thatch and bamboo they had brought with them to build the first cottage. When Viswanadhan woke the next morning he saw the sprout of a seed on one of the tiny palm trees planted to demarcate the boundary of the land which a group of over 30 artists had collectively purchased to build India's first artists' village.

A towering banyan tree now stands where the palm once did. The innocuous little sprout which had embraced and engulfed the palm tree kept growing like, well, Jack's beanstalk: you can barely see the trunk of the dead palm tree. The Cholamandal Artists' Village also grew exponentially. There's barely any trace of quaint huts with thatched roofs or a makeshift museum. Bohemia has all but disappeared from the Village: bricks, mortar, cement and the influx of money from various corporations have transformed what may have been an imagined utopia for the group of former students of the Madras School of Arts. Spurred on by the late KCS Paniker, painter and principal of the college, who moved to Cholamandal after he retired, the artists created a community where they could live and work—on land they owned and in homes

and studios they built themselves.

Cholamandal celebrated 50 years of its existence in February, with much fanfare and culminating with an inspired recital by TM Krishna. The release of a catalogue of Cholamandal's art collection titled *The Museum of the Madras Movement* was followed by the inauguration of paintings and sculptures of 55 of its renowned artists, including those of Reddeppa Naidu, M Senathipathi, PS Nandhan, KM Adimoolam, C Dakshinamoorthy, Akkitham Narayanan, J Sultan Ali, V Viswanadhan and SG Vasudev.

The "Village", in what is now considered a posh neighbourhood, is on the map for tourists on their way to Mahabalipuram, and beyond. You can see visitors wandering through the international sculpture garden, outdoor theatre and the various galleries. Artists can also rent the contemporary art gallery to exhibit their works. If you strain your ears, you can hear sculptors chiselling granite. Works of art spill on to verandas and gardens in many of the homes and studios.

On the surface the bustling artists' commune is a happening place. However, the buzz is deceptive. It is no longer on the radar of the ruling clique of art theorists and critics in the rest of the country—and rarely part of the discourse on modern and contemporary art in India. Cholamandal artists dominated the Madras Movement which was started in the late 1950s by Paniker. Perhaps it is time to restore it to its rightful place. The educationist formed the Progressive Painters' Association in 1944, three years before the much-touted but short-lived and inordinately influential Progressive Artists' Group of Bombay which dispersed a few years after it was established in 1947.

The Movement lasted about 30 years, and brought Modernism to South India. However,



Photograph: Nadine Tarbouriech

this "ism" was no mere transplant; it acquired a regional vocabulary on southern soil. "Mr Panicker encouraged us to be open to Western art while drawing sustenance from tradition," explains the founder-member painter Viswanadhan who divides his time between Paris and Cholamandal. "He told us to look around locally. Even an ordinary scarecrow in the field had an interesting form and could inspire us."

Spearheaded by Paniker, the artists explored "new premises for contemporary Indian art" according to the late Josef James, art historian and chronicler of the Madras Movement and the Artists' Village. Drawing gained importance, as did the line and the "expressivity of the line". Paniker's distinctive paintings include notations, jottings, writing, marks and lines. Inspired by him, many of his students began to incorporate lines and writing in their canvases.

Paniker's most enduring legacy may have been the establishment of Cholamandal. Many of his students had been forced to abandon art and take up jobs. The Village allowed art-

ists to continue being artists and earn a living—usually by marrying art and craft. They formed an Artists' Handicrafts Association and bought paint and canvases with the money they earned by selling handicrafts. Viswanadhan says he made Rs 1,000 a month selling the batik saris he made. During the commemoration, Cholamandal artists M Senathipathi, S Nandagopal (Paniker's son), P Gopinath and Viswanadhan expressed their gratitude for Paniker's envisioning a cultural space without any funding from the government—a place where new ideas could come into play and the artists could be self-reliant.

Cholamandal Artists' Village can no longer boast of being an artists-only village. Over 15 of the original artists who settled here have either died or moved out. Their houses are now occupied by entrepreneurs, journalists and other professionals. Perhaps it is time to encourage young artists to settle here again.

The recent cyclone brought down several thousand tons of trees: the debris is evident everywhere. But the banyan tree still stands sentinel.

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Image courtesy: urbanasia.com

Real-life Dummies

By Shougat Dasgupta

One of the world's great tourist traps, a Victorian relic, comes to India

Madame Tussauds, the world famous waxwork “museum”, opens in Delhi this summer, though no precise date has yet been announced. It’s a wonder it has taken so long. Tussauds, a fusty Victorian relic that is a worldwide phenomenon, an accoutrement for aspiring “global” cities. Four Chinese cities have a Tussauds, five if you count Hong Kong. In London, where the first Tussauds opened its doors to the public in 1836, people of South Asian origin make up about 14 per cent of the population. Indian pop culture, or at least Bollywood, is intrinsic to London and thus represented in Tussauds in a way that Chinese culture, for instance, is not.

Waxworks of film stars are common. Amitabh Bachchan and Shah Rukh Khan are obvious candidates. But Aishwarya Rai was in Tussauds before Shah Rukh. Others include Salman Khan, Madhuri Dixit, Kareena Kapoor, Hrithik Roshan, even Katrina Kaif. A wax model of Prime Minister Narendra Modi was unveiled last April, while Sachin Tendulkar has been on display since 2009. The first waxwork of an Indian in Tussauds was, of course, Mahatma Gandhi, though not until the 1960s. Jawaharlal Nehru, Indira Gandhi, and Rajiv Gandhi have all been memorialised in wax. More unexpectedly, so has PV Narasimha Rao.

Given this history, and given, say, a city like Mumbai’s fixation with celebrity it’s genuinely surprising that it has taken this long for a Tussauds to make its way to India and that Delhi should be its first home. That home will be in Connaught Place, on the first two floors of the once grand, now restored Regal Cinema. The space is expected to house about 50 waxworks and the promoters are being cagey

about the identities of the celebrities visitors might expect to see. The waxworks of Indian stars already in circulation will doubtless make their way to Delhi; at Rs 1.5 crore a pop, it makes economic sense to select celebrities with an eye to longevity. Alongside the likes of Bachchan, Rai and the Khans, will be the likes of Beyoncé, Lady Gaga and Kim Kardashian. At a press conference in Delhi to announce the imminent arrival of Tussauds, the Gaga waxwork accompanied Bachchan.

According to Tussauds, 60 per cent of the celebrities on display will be Indian. Their selection will be interesting, if only as a window into who Tussauds thinks is emblematic of India in 2017. Reports already indicate an Arvind Kejriwal statue is in the works. Tussauds could do worse than look to the waxwork museums that already abound in India for inspiration. Sunil’s Celebrity Museum in Maharashtra contains the usual Bollywood stars but also the likes of Shivaji and Sharad Pawar. At Mother’s Wax Museum in Kolkata, the selection provides an insight into Bengali preoccupations (male, naturally). Tagore is there, and Vivekananda, and AJC Bose, but so is Manna Dey, Maradona and Mithun Chakraborty in gleaming white. In December, a waxwork museum, featuring Einstein and Michael Jackson, opened in Jaipur. Govinda cut the ribbon, looking, like so many movie stars, extraordinarily like a waxwork brought by some strange alchemy to temporary life.

There is something charming about these peculiar juxtapositions, about Einstein, say, and Mithun occupying the same space not because of their respective achievements but because they exert a hold on the public imagination. How dispiriting it would be if Tussauds fails to replicate this quixotic mix, choosing instead to feature cricket captains and Big Boss contestants, as if the public

is no longer moved by ideas, character and eccentricity but by marketing and vacuous self-promotion.

In the past, Tussauds’ waxworks were roped off, the public held at arm’s length. On display were the great and the good, sometimes as tableaux, in the midst of battle or signing a treaty. It was still democratic. Or rather carnivalesque, in that ordinary people were released from convention, were permitted to rant and rave at politicians and aristocrats, to hold their heads up insolently high before their queen. Accessibility to those not normally accessible was the draw, the reassuring corporeality of those who might as well have been gods. Our contemporary gods are theoretically more accessible, even if walled off by security, by wealth. At Tussauds they are not just theoretically accessible; they’re right there in front of us, unresisting. But they’re not real, you might object. Who needs celebrities to be real? They might as well be waxworks in that their chief function is to serve as blank space onto which we project our own desires, fears, dreams.

As in the 19th or mid-20th centuries, when Tussauds was a space where you were for once on level terms with your “betters”, today it’s a space where those in the foreground recede into the background, provide the mise en scène for us, the stars of our own selfies. There is still subversive fun in the casual irreverence we show towards the waxworks in Tussauds as opposed to the veneration our culture lavishes on celebrities.

All that said, the first waxwork Marie Tussaud made was of Voltaire. Her labour and artistry was in aid of history, was to retard the passing of time, or at least salvage something from its wreckage. From Voltaire to Kim Kardashian is some journey, just don’t think too much about the direction.

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The Poet-Scholar

By Trisha Gupta

*A conversation with **Guillermo Rodriguez**, the author of *When Mirrors are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics* (OUP, 2016) and the founding director of Casa de la India, a pioneering cultural centre in Spain.*

How did you encounter the work of AK Ramanujan?

In the summer of 1993, after an overland trip from Spain to India, I was living on a houseboat in Banaras and among the first books I picked up was a volume of his translations of medieval Kannada mystical poems, *Speaking of Siva*, and R Parthasarathy's anthology, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, which included several poems by Ramanujan. I was struck by the unusual imagery and magical power of suggestion of his poems, as well as by the mysterious quality of the translations, which contained ancient wisdom in a surprisingly provocative fresh language and almost riddle-like form.

Why did you decide to study his work for your PhD? What sustained your interest?

In 1997, for my master's dissertation at Loyola College, Chennai, I did a stylistic and symbolic study of a single poem by AKR titled "Snakes", from his first poetry book *The Striders* (1966). I was fascinated by the way the meaning of the poem comes to the reader in its *design*, in the particular way the poet-narrator renders the experience through the linguistic structure, while the symbolism of the snake allows for interpretations from the psychological (Jungian), philosophical and mythological (Hindu) perspective. That was Ramanujan's trademark style. His multilayered art and poetics came from his being exposed to, and having absorbed in his poetry, multiple traditions and disciplines—in India and then in America.

Also, at a crucial moment, Girish Karnad, Ramanujan's friend since the 1950s, encouraged me to look at the *A.K. Ramanujan Papers*, deposited at the University of Chicago in 1994. The papers turned out to be a treasure trove—the unpublished notebooks, diaries, journals and letters of one of 20th-century India's most seminal intellectuals.

Ramanujan brings together the Indian classical, the regional and the Western traditions in a way that might be unique. Your book quotes him as saying: "I write in two traditions and I belong to at least three."

As a Tamil Brahmin who grew up in Mysore, AKR was surrounded by four languages (Kannada, English, Tamil, Sanskrit) and received a trilingual formal education. He did not learn Sanskrit formally but absorbed it as a religious language from his father. He wrote poetry in two languages, English and Kannada, and translated mainly from Kannada and

Tamil into English. His father was a mathematician and was also steeped in Indian philosophy. Kannada was AKR's first literary language: he wrote plays in it his early college days in the 1940s, before becoming part of the *navya* (new) modernist poetry scene in Kannada in the 1950s. He was also deeply influenced by oral literatures and medieval *Virasaiva* Kannada *bhakti* poetry, which appealed to his rebellious nature in his youth. By 30, he had become somewhat tired of being a professor of English in Indian provincial towns, and in 1959 he went to the US as a Fulbright scholar of linguistics. It was there that he learned to translate the Tamil classics, becoming Professor of Dravidian Studies at the University of Chicago in the early 1960s.

Many 20th century Indian writers had a similarly multilayered upbringing (regional, pan-Indian, English). What is unique about AKR is how he made use of these traditions in a profoundly rich, yet apparently simple, natural way; how he creatively absorbed and displayed these layers in his English-language poetry; and the success with which he translated between these languages (of different cultures and literary periods).

Did his poetry inform his translations? And vice versa?

AKR's English-language poetry contained much from the Indian poetic traditions he translated. He imitated conventions from Tamil classical literature, such as Sangam poetics (metonymic "inner landscapes", understatement, poetic economy, dramatic scenes, poetry cycles etc), Tamil prayer forms (in mock prayer-poems such as "Prayer to Lord Murugan") and the fourth-century Tamil *Kural* (in the couplets used in poetic sequences in his collection *Second Sight*). Also, much of his poetry was preoccupied with the concept of grace and *anubhāva*

(mystical experience) found in *Virasaiva* poets, and the paradoxical notion of poetic inspiration as an "ordinary mystery".

Though he believed that "only poems can translate poems", his training in linguistics was fundamental to "transpose" the original faithfully into a new "poetic body", making use of syntactic devices and modulation, structural and visual design, texture and images.

Some have charged AKR with infusing his translations, especially the early 1970s renderings of the *Virasaiva vachanas* with a modernist, ironic style which distorts the original voices. These critics say he could not free himself from his Western modernist attitude à la Carlos Williams, Wallace Stevens and Ezra Pound. But we should not forget that he was living in Chicago and translating into the idiom of the American reader of the 1970s. His translations made these unknown South Indian poetic traditions come alive in a contemporary language.

How did moving to the US shape Ramanujan's sense of himself and his writing?

His was a self-chosen exile, and he took it as a mediating role between Indian and American scholarship and as a dialogue in himself. Despite the inevitable disconnection from his native culture and family relations, he believed that no part of the self could be isolated from the other.

And this notion permeates his creative writing, where there's a constant give-and-take among different components (America, English literature and the diverse Indian traditions). Ironically, it was in the US where AKR discovered Tamil Classical Poetry when, in 1962, he chanced upon an anthology of Sangam poets in the basement of the University of Chicago Library. He half-seriously called himself "the hyphen in Indo-American Studies." ■